

The Empire That Wasn't Evil

A world-review digest — everything figured out so far

Daggerheart setting · compiled 2026-08-13 · GM eyes (full spoilers) · source of truth remains the vault notes

An enormous, centuries-old empire that is *genuinely good at governing* — safe roads, fair courts, low crime, protected trade, preserved cultures, no slavery, a citizenry that genuinely likes it. And yet there is a rebellion whose members are *not obviously wrong*. The campaign is the slow discovery of **why anyone would destroy a government that works** — and the players cannot resolve it by picking the good guys, because there are none. They decide what kind of world they actually want.

How to read this on your walk: it goes surface-first, the way the players meet the world — the pitch, then the land, the peoples, the players' own court, the rebellion and its faces — and only at the end descends into the GM secret buried under all of it. Everything here is drafted and committed; the two big undecided pieces (the secret's exact mechanism, and locking the provisional names) are flagged at the close.

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1 · The Premise & the Design Contract

Players arrive expecting the standard fantasy furniture — imperial bureaucracy, military occupation, conquered peoples, noble houses, court intrigue, rebellion — and it is *all there*. But the assumption underneath it is wrong. **The Empire works, and people know it:**

- Roads are safe and maintained; trade moves; merchants are protected.
- Crime is low. Courts are relatively fair — even to the conquered.
- Famines are rare; the granaries function.

- Conquered cultures keep their languages, gods, and customs.
- Slavery was abolished centuries ago.
- The average citizen genuinely *likes* the Empire — not from propaganda, but because their life is demonstrably better under it.

And yet there is a rebellion, and the rebels are decent people with a real grievance. The wrongness the players feel is *not* "the Empire is secretly cruel." It is "*why would anyone burn this down?*" That question is the hook; its answer is the iceberg.

The central question: Why destroy a government that works? → and beneath it → *is a government that works worth what it costs to work?* Players are never handed this as exposition; they back into it by doing their jobs and noticing the peace has a seam in it.

THE LOAD-BEARING RULE — DO NOT VIOLATE

*Both the Empire's defenders and the rebels must stay **right** for the entire campaign.*

The test for any secret, faction, or reveal: *could a thoughtful, decent person, knowing the full truth, still choose to keep it running?* If the answer becomes "no," the story has collapsed into Evil Empire / Plucky Rebels — the exact cliché this premise exists to transcend. Keep the benefit vast and real; keep the cost real and never hand-waved; keep the choice genuinely hard.

On the name: the hegemon is simply "the Empire" — intentional, not a placeholder. From inside, it is not *an* empire among rivals; it is *the* order of the world, the water everyone swims in. (Revisit only if a rival power or outside perspective demands contrast.)

Tone & authoring rule: comfort and competence first (a world worth loving) → *uncanny* when the seam shows → *grimdark spikes* at the pressure points. Teach through "something is weird," never an encyclopedia dump. The peace is real; the cost is real; everyone is grateful.

2 • What the Setting Is About

Is a government that works worth what it costs to work?

"Good" and "right" are not the same word. A just, humane, beloved order can rest on something unforgivable — and the people it shelters are not fools for loving it. The question is never "are they

the bad guys?" It's "knowing everything, what would you keep, and what would you refuse — and who pays either way?"

THE ARC OF REALIZATION

"We serve a government that works." → "The peace has a seam in it." → "The peace is *bought*." → "The price is real, and so is the thing it buys." → "We have to decide what kind of world we want — because there is no answer that costs nothing."

SUPPORTING MOTIFS

- **Complicity is the water, not the villain.** The players don't observe the system from outside; they *are* it. They dispense its justice. The horror isn't done *to* them — it's done *through* them, and was already being done before they arrived.
- **The gentle euphemism.** Language that lets good people *not look* — a warm word for a terrible thing, spoken as a blessing by someone who genuinely means it. Recognition, not cruelty, is the danger.
- **The cost is invisible by design.** A system this humane stays humane *because* almost no one ever has to witness what it's built on. Seeing clearly is itself the transgression.
- **Comfort as the thing you're complicit in.** Wonder here is not *vistas* — it's a world that *works*, that you'd genuinely want to live in. That's what's at stake, and what makes the choice hard.
- **Rebellion as conscience; order as mercy.** The rebels see the cost and cannot abide it. The Empire sees the alternative and cannot risk it. Both are acts of care. Neither is a lie.
- **No clean hands, no undo.** Whatever the players choose, someone pays. The finale is a *decision with a price*, not a victory that removes it.

3 · The Players' Vantage — The Assize

The players are a **mixed commission of inquiry / circuit court** — *a job, not an imposed identity*. It rides province to province, holds a sitting, settles what the local machinery couldn't, and rides on. It is one of the Empire's three separated powers (Governors hold · Circuits judge · the Rolls count), and it is the reason "the courts are fair, even to the conquered" is *true* rather than propaganda: the judge has no local stake and does not stay to profit from the verdict.

Why this frame:

- **Job, not identity.** The GM imposes exactly one thing — *you all serve this body*. Who each character is, and whether they privately love or despise the Empire, is entirely player-

authored.

- **The central argument happens between the PCs.** Believers and skeptics at the same table means the moral parallax is live in the party, not just PC-vs-NPC.
- **Complicity is built in.** The players personally dispense the Empire's justice — the horror is something they are *part of*.
- **Episodic content is free.** Each province / case is a self-contained arc that resolves satisfyingly *and* seeds the iceberg.

WHAT IT CAN AND CANNOT DO

The Assize CAN	The Assize CANNOT
Hear and rule on cases referred up or petitioned to it	Govern — no taxes, garrison, works, or appointments (that's the Governor)
Summon witnesses, compel testimony, examine sites during its sitting	Keep the count — it may consult the Rolls but not amend them
Overturn or confirm a local magistrate's ruling on appeal	Legislate — it applies imperial law; it does not make it
Judge the Governor's own officers — cases no local court can touch	Rule the province after it leaves — authority is present-tense only
Issue writs and execute them through its own small detail	Reach beyond its sitting — once it rides on, it's just travellers

A Governor is powerful, permanent, and *local*; the Assize is powerful, momentary, and *from away*. Neither can become the other, and each is the check the other cannot corrupt.

THE SEATS (PARTY COMPOSITION MAPS TO REAL FUNCTIONS)

Seat	Function	Maps to
Presiding Justice	Holds the warrant, runs the sitting, signs the verdict. <i>Default: an NPC — the party's anchor & moral mirror.</i>	patron / anchor
Examiners (several)	The field arm — gather facts, question witnesses, walk the ground, make arrests. Most PCs sit here.	fighters, rogues, rangers, a physician-examiner
Intercessor	Bridges tongue and custom; sees both truths at once.	a face PC, ideally from a conquered people

Serjeant	The court's muscle — bailiff, protection, executes writs. Commands a small detail.	warrior, guardian, ex-soldier
Recorder	Keeps the record, files the verdict, and <i>reads the Rolls</i> .	scholar, knowledge PC

THE RIDING SEASON IS THE CAMPAIGN STRUCTURE

The court sets out from the Aureenne after the roads open, works down the Vaur and its branches in a known order — placid **Aureenne** (tutorial) → proud **Halden** (custom vs. statute) → raw **Kessad** (the moral heat) → eerie **Outmark** (the quiet that shouldn't be so quiet) — and returns to the centre before the season closes.

Running an arc — one rule: the case resolves satisfyingly, and leaves exactly one thing that doesn't add up. The docket lands → the examiners work → the commission deliberates and the Justice rules (*genuine justice is done — non-negotiable*) → one seed is left un-explained. Never explain the seed in the arc that plants it; let it *rhyme* with the next, sessions later.

The pitch to players, one line: *you are the fair court that rides in when no one local can be trusted to judge — and you are very good at your job.*

4 • The Land

The one-sentence shape: a great temperate river-basin at the heart of a contiguous continent, ringed by uplands and reached by a long coast — a landmass generous enough to grow a surplus, and connected enough to move it before anyone starves.

Geography does real work here — the Empire is prosperous *because of where it is*, not only how it's run:

- **The interior heights (the Reave)** — a high snow-holding range, the water tower feeding the rivers.
- **The great basin (the Aurene)** — broad well-watered lowland; the Empire's cradle and breadbasket.
- **The trunk river (the Vaur) & its canal spine** — navigable, canal-laced; grain, stone, timber, and law travel by water where they can.
- **The uplands** — cooler, harder pasture-and-ore country (the Halden).
- **The warm lowlands** — rich hot deltas, most fertile and most recently taken (Kessad).
- **The coast (the Sarne)** — mild maritime edge; the Empire's window on trade beyond itself.
- **The marches** — the thin cold edge where the network runs out (the Outmark).

WHY THE PROSPERITY IS PLAUSIBLE

A large temperate breadbasket grows more than it needs → rivers and canals carry the surplus cheaply and far → a bad harvest is a *local* problem, not a death. Famine, the ordinary terror of the pre-modern world, is here rare — and the machinery that makes it rare is visible to everyone. *Prosperity is not decreed; it is plumbed.* The same network moves post, judges, soldiers, and coin.

THE THREE RINGS — DISTANCE FROM THE NETWORK

The Empire is best understood not as borders but as how fully a place is woven into the system of roads, rivers, rolls, and courts:

1. **The Core (heartland).** Old basin provinces around the capital — governed most lightly *because they need it least*. The Empire is invisible the way good plumbing is invisible.
2. **The Provinces (settled middle).** Older conquests, thoroughly integrated; they keep their languages, gods, and customs, pay their assessments, and prosper.

3. **The Marches (frontier & recently-pacified).** Two flavours — recently-pacified provinces still raw with contested gratitude, and the true frontier where the network thins to a thread and stops.

The genius: the rings are **permeable in one direction**. A march becomes a province becomes core. The implicit promise to the newly-conquered is not "submit," but "*wait — in a generation this will be you*" — and often, visibly, it has been.

THE THREE SEPARATED POWERS

- **The Governors** hold a province — order, garrison, works, assessment. Powerful and local, and deliberately *cannot judge their own subjects*.
- **The Circuit Courts** ride through on a fixed calendar, answerable to the centre. Justice arrives from outside and leaves — which is why it is trusted. (The Assize is one such circuit.)
- **The Rolls** — census, survey, tax and grain ledgers — kept by a scribal service loyal only to the accuracy of the count. How the Empire *knows itself*.

Over all three sits the centre, whose real instrument of power is not an army but **information moving faster than trouble** — the relay-post.

5 • The Four Provinces

The Aurenne — the core

HEARTLAND • CAPITAL • THE MODEL OF AT HOME IN A PLACE THAT WORKS

The deep, well-watered lowland where the Empire began — cradle, breadbasket, and seat. Oldest-settled, most prosperous, *least visibly* governed: the machinery has faded into the background of everyday life. People don't feel ruled; they feel at home. The capital (**Vaurehm**, at the head of navigation) is a city of archives and granaries more than palaces — power that looks like ledgers and warehouses, not walls. The heartland's towns pulled down their walls generations ago and built granaries on the footings; safety is so assumed it has become architecture.

The Halden — a settled province

UPLANDS · LONG-INTEGRATED · THE MODEL OF CONTENT

Hard hill-country — pasture, ore, terraced grain, stone villages, and a famously stubborn people who will tell you at length how different they are from the soft basin-folk (in the Empire's common tongue, over Empire-taxed ale, having just won in an imperial court). Conquered so long ago it's a schoolroom date, not a wound. When the Halden harvest fails, grain comes upriver and *no one dies* — that single lived fact is the root of their loyalty. This is the province that proves "a march becomes a province becomes, near enough, core."

Kessad — recently pacified

SOUTHERN DELTA · TAKEN WITHIN LIVING MEMORY · THE MODEL OF CONTESTED GRATITUDE

Hot, staggeringly fertile delta — walled river-cities (capital: **Ish-Karan**) that were sophisticated and self-governing when the Empire arrived two generations ago. It was not a wilderness that got civilized; it was a civilization that *lost*. Now prosperous, orderly, fairly judged — and full of people who buried someone in the taking. The tell of recent conquest: *two of everything* — two calendars, two names for every street, two memories of the same war (the imperial *pacification*, bloodless in the telling; the Kessadi *siege*, with a body count). The circuit court's job here is often to adjudicate which memory the law will honour — not a neutral act, and everyone knows it. The province a thoughtful rebellion recruits from first.

The Outmark — the true frontier

COLD EDGE · GARRISON LINE · THE SETTING'S MOST PATIENT QUESTION

Marginal country at the rim — high, cold, poor ground held not by farmland but by **the line**: a chain of garrison-forts and relay-stations along the last of the trunk-road. Duty here is unglamorous and coveted for exactly that reason: it is *quiet*. Nothing comes over the line. It hasn't, in generations. Stand at the last milestone, look at the empty country beyond, and understand that everything behind you stops *here* — held by these cold forts and the people in them. Even here, no garrison starves; the granary system reaches the rim. (*The quiet is the hook — see the secret.*)

6 • The Four Peoples

One per ring, one per stance toward the Empire — a spectrum from invisible-default to aggrieved to dutiful-edge.

The Vaurin — the basin-folk who forgot they are a people

HOMELAND: THE AURENNE · LANGUAGE: IMPERIAL COMMON · STANCE: COMFORTABLE, BLIND

The heartland majority whose tongue became Imperial Common and whose habits became "normal." The crucial fact: they experience themselves as having *no* ethnicity — the way tap water has no flavour. Ask a Vaurin their traditions and they'll describe *the Empire's* holidays. To everyone else they're unmistakably a people with a very strong flavour.

Kept: everything — and so they never *notice* keeping it. **Lost:** the awareness of being distinct. They love the Empire the way you love a climate, without noticing. The most dangerous phrase in the Empire is a Vaurin magistrate saying, in perfect good faith, "*I have no bias; I simply apply the law.*"

Their piety is *practical continuity* — the tended granary, the kept ledger, being *counted* accurately in the Rolls. Their civic speech is full of warm procedural blessings: "*may your rolls be clean,*" "*settled and squared,*" "*reconciled and at peace.*" Genuinely kind — and the exact register the gentle euphemism hides inside. (*The believer PC is very likely Vaurin by default: the reader's own assumptions, given a homeland.*) Dominance is not totality — older minority cultures persist in hard-to-reach pockets where the network's smoothing pressure is weakest.

The Haldar — the genuinely content

HOMELAND: THE HALDEN · LANGUAGE: HALDIC · STANCE: WARM, EARNED

Hill-clans conquered so long ago the conquest is a date in a book. **Kept:** dialect, hill-gods, festivals, clan structure, pride, and their old (now decorative) walls. **Lost:** the raiding — the feuds and lean-year killings the Empire ended by roping the uplands into the network. Ask an elder what the Empire took and she'll struggle to name a thing she misses.

The *design-contract anchor* — the living argument that the Empire is worth defending; never let them curdle into "sellouts." But the split matters: the **old** love the Empire as the thing that ended the raiding; the **young** are more Haldar-proud and less grateful, because they never saw the before. *The grievance the Empire should fear is not here yet — but you can watch the ground for it.* Their custom of the **kept walls** — an annual armed watch against an enemy the Empire made extinct, that they no longer quite remember — faintly rhymes with the frontier that went quiet.

The Kessadi (the Karesh) — the aggrieved civilization

HOMELAND: KESSAD · LANGUAGE: KARESH · STANCE: IT IS NOT ONE THING

A delta civilization taken within living memory. Among themselves the old federation is **the Karesh** — the Sworn Cities. **Kept:** language, delta-gods, pre-imperial canals, their own notable families (still administering under an imperial governor). **Lost:** sovereignty, coin, and — the wound that matters — their **water-judges:** hereditary colleges that settled water-rights and all law from the same bench. The Empire kept the canal-engineering and stripped the judging. To the Empire, its proudest gift; to the Kessadi, the precise organ of their identity, cut out and mailed back as a courtesy.

The uncomfortable twist: the old Karesh order was an *oligarchy* of water-judge houses, and imperial law is measurably *fairer to the common Kessadi than their own city ever was*. The people with the sharpest grievance are the people who used to be on top. The **Phantom Assizes** — surviving water-judge families still "hearing cases" once a year in a law no one will enforce — are grief wearing the robes of a court, and the most Kessadi thing there is.

The Tallun — the dutiful edge

HOMELAND: THE OUTMARK · LANGUAGE: TALUNNIC · STANCE: NEITHER GRIEVANCE NOR COMFORT — DUTY

Scattered marchfolk not so much conquered as *absorbed* when the line was drawn through their country. Their bargain is the plainest of all: *the forts feed us, and nothing crosses the line.*

Kept: kin-bands, cairn-marking, weather-lore, the Talunnic tongue (full of words for kinds of cold and kinds of quiet). **Lost:** freedom of movement across country that is now *the line*, and independence from the interior's food. The one place the Empire and a conquered people have genuinely *fused*: a Tallun today is as likely a soldier's grandchild as a trapper's, usually both.

Their whole culture is shaped to read, for many sessions, as ordinary frontier folkways: **cairn-keeping** (a cairn is added to, never finished; the dead are cairned, not buried); the taboo against **naming what's-beyond-the-line** directly (the Long Guest, the Far Weather, "what the cairns face" — naming a thing is halfway to calling it); and **the Watch** — kept on the wall your grandfather kept, facing the country he faced, though nothing has ever come. What grievance exists is not political — it is *being forgotten*. A Tallun wants the basin to remember the line is held by someone.

7 • The Rebellion — The Sworn

The delta movement to win back Kessadi self-judgment — and the campaign's hardest mirror. Not terrorists, not liberators: decent people responding to a real wrong, who cannot agree among themselves what the wrong *is* or what would put it right. The faithful invoke the old water-oath and call themselves **the Sworn** — the Sworn Cities, swearing it a second time. Every rebel can name a true loss. That is the point and the trap: *the losses are not the same loss, and the people who lost most are not the people the Empire treated worst.*

WHY NOW — FOUR PRESSURES CONVERGING

- **The window is closing.** The new imperial trunk-road is finished; garrisons that took a season to reinforce can now be resupplied in days. Anyone who means to act by force must act *before* the road makes force pointless. The road built the peace and the deadline in one stroke.
- **The last reconciliation.** The scribal service has just completed the final "reconciling of the delta rolls" — post-siege census cleanup, to the Empire. To the Sworn, the day the Karesh were formally *counted out of existence*, and the last unregistered ancestral water-shares were surveyed away.
- **The memory is dying.** The siege generation — the last who remember being free rather than being told they were saved — is nearly gone.
- **A fair verdict that wounded.** The spark is usually a *just* ruling — a circuit court correctly applying imperial law to confirm a seizure or dispossess a beloved figure who was, in law, wrong. *The Sworn are radicalized as often by the Empire's fairness as by its cruelty — which is why the players' own body can light the fuse without doing anything unjust.*

WHAT THEY WANT (THEY DO NOT AGREE) — THREE WINGS

- **The Restorationists** — the water-judge houses and their clients. Aim: *restore the bench*. The movement's money, respectability, and organizing skeleton — sincere, cultured, and quietly asking the delta to hand power back to the people who used to have it.
- **The Dispossessed** — commoners the imperial "improvement" left behind, and the siege-bereaved. Aim: *redress, not restoration*. They know the water-judges never helped them either; their loyalty to the Restorationists is brittle.
- **The hardliners** — the young, and those who took the imperial ladder and hit its ceiling. Aim: *sovereignty, whatever replaces it*. They want the Empire gone, and are straining toward force.

The deliberately vague banner that holds all three: "**our law, our bench, our water.**" Everyone hears a different promise in it. The Sworn have no head; they organize through the Phantom Assizes — a legitimate-seeming civic body that cannot be outlawed without outlawing a funeral rite — with compartmented cells hanging around it that the convening does not control. Methods run civil → sabotage → insurgency, and the movement is *straining* between them.

8 • The Three Faces of the Rebellion

Nemara Ishekar — the conscience

HEIR OF A WATER-JUDGE HOUSE • PRESIDES AT THE PHANTOM ASSIZES • FLAT ARC, TESTED TO BREAKING

Middle-aged, precise, unshowy — she'd have been a fine judge in any system, and knows it, and that is her wound. She keeps a dead court alive out of grief and discovered too late that grief makes an excellent flag. She didn't build the Sworn; it grew around her convening like ivy around a post. **Truth she holds:** a people that cannot judge itself is not a people. **The break she fears:** the day she must choose between denouncing the violence her legitimacy shelters (shattering the movement) or blessing it with silence (becoming the thing she judged). The party's most reasonable point of contact inside the Sworn — put her in the room whenever the table drifts toward "rebels = terrorists."

Davan Kesharan — the firebrand who built what he now destroys

FORMER IMPERIAL SURVEYOR • RUNS THE CELLS • NEGATIVE, DESCENDING ARC

A Kessadi who took the imperial ladder, trained as a surveyor, and helped map the water-reallocation that dispossessed his own neighbours before he understood what the lines meant. Now he runs the cells that cut the network he charted. Where Nemara argues law, Davan argues *arithmetic*: here is what they took, here is the schedule, here is where it breaks. **Lie he's building toward:** the only clean thing left is to destroy it. **Descent:** sabotage → "warnings" → the first body → an open rising timed to the closing road-window. His tragedy: he is *right about the wrong* and becoming monstrous in answering it. (*He is the natural mouth for the fringe ledger-seed — see the secret — but kept wrong in a rhyming way.*)

Marsu of the Low Wharfs — the human ground truth

LOCK-KEEPER · SHELTERS THE SWORN · POSITIVE, TORN ARC

The whole tragedy at kitchen-table scale. She lost an ancestral water-share to the reconciliation and a brother to the siege; she feeds the Sworn out of loyalty and grief — and is terrified the movement will destroy the one thing the Empire actually gave her: her clever son's posting in imperial service. She has done the sums the poets won't: under the old bench her family drowned in lean years while the houses adjudicated; under the Empire, nobody drowns, and her son can *rise*. **Need:** to choose, openly, and own the cost — instead of letting grief and fear decide by default. She is the design contract's "*could a decent person refuse the rebellion?*" made flesh.

9 • The Cost

This fixes the *direction* and the *design constraint*; the exact mechanism is deliberately still open (the next big build task). Never surfaced as exposition — revealed only through the iceberg.

THE DIRECTION: A FUSION

The stability is bought two ways at once, and the two halves reinforce each other:

1. **A small, ongoing, unbearable act.** For centuries the Empire has quietly paid a price in *people* — a tiny number, chosen and "spent" so the vast majority can live in peace, fairness, and plenty. Utilitarian bookkeeping at the scale of a civilization: a rounding error of lives for the safety of millions.
2. **...that also holds something worse at bay.** The act is load-bearing against a *returning catastrophe* — something the founding generation faced, survived, and has been keeping at the door ever since. The sacrifice is the lock on that door.

Neither half alone is enough. Sacrifice-the-few alone reads as cruelty-with-good-PR; a dam-against-the-dark alone risks "the Empire was right all along." **Fused, they hold the parallax:** the cost is genuinely monstrous *and* the benefit is genuinely real *and* the danger is genuinely uncertain.

THE KNIFE — WHAT KEEPS BOTH SIDES RIGHT

No one alive has seen the threat. It has been held back so long, so well, that whether it is *still real* — or ever was as terrible as the founding claims — cannot be known from inside the peace.

- **The Empire's defenders are right:** stop paying and you may unleash a horror no one remembers how to survive. Every generation that paid was "proven right" by the fact that nothing came.
- **The rebels are right:** you are murdering people, generation after generation, to ward off a danger you *cannot even confirm exists* — and calling it peace.

Players get a **complete answer to "what is the cost,"** a **sufficient answer to "what is the threat,"** and — by design — **no certain answer to "is it still necessary."** That last question is not a fact to be uncovered; it is the *choice*, and it belongs to the players.

THE EUPHEMISM (CANDIDATE, NOT LOCKED)

A warm word that lets good people not-look, spoken as a blessing by those who mean well. Strong candidate: **"reconciliation"** — to be *reconciled* is the gentle civic term for being the one who pays. (*"It's why we've had such peace since."*) Kept deliberately *out* of the players' job title so the word stays rare — surfacing in frontier garrison ledgers, old deeds, and the scribal "reconcile the rolls."

THE THREE ICEBERG SEEDS ALREADY PLANTED (ALL DENIABLE, NONE CONFIRMING ANYTHING)

- **The "reconciled" ledger / "reconciling the rolls."** Routine bookkeeping — balancing the census against reality, a name struck off, a household that no longer answers the count. Reads as pure bureaucracy. Is also, precisely, the warm word for the thing the Empire quietly pays. Lives most naturally in Vaurin mouths and cold garrison ledgers.
- **The Outmark's unbroken silence.** Pacified fast, silent since — forts manned, nothing ever coming. To players, a triumph of imperial reach. Later: *what exactly are those forts holding the door against, if nothing ever comes?* The "dam" half. The Tallun taboo against naming what's-beyond, and their Watch against a thing that never comes, embody the "seeing clearly is the transgression" motif in the people standing closest to it.
- **The Zero Stone / impossible milestone counts.** Imperial roads are measured from a marker no living surveyor can locate, and the oldest roads' counts run higher than the Empire's own founding records allow. The land was being measured before there was anyone here to measure it — land older than the Empire. A curiosity for a long time.

THE ONE FRINGE SEED INSIDE THE REBELLION

A single fringe cell — a Kessadi clerk who once worked the scribal service — insists the reconciliation lists *don't balance*: more names come off the delta rolls than death and emigration explain, on a fixed schedule. His theory is a *mundane atrocity theory* (a hidden imperial labour-levy, a tax in people, a disappearance he calls corruption) — **wrong in a way that rhymes with the truth without touching it**. The Sworn's own council thinks he's a crank; the belief stays fringe even inside the movement. Its late payoff: the crank was righter than anyone, and also wronger. *The Sworn as a body never suspect the secret* — the players reach it through the frontier's silence, not the delta's anger.

DESIGN CONSTRAINT — INHERITED, DO NOT VIOLATE

Everything about the mechanism must pass the test: *could a thoughtful, decent person, knowing the full truth, still choose to keep it running?* Keep the victims **few**; the benefit **vast and real**; the threat **genuinely uncertain**; the selection **not obviously unjust** (not "the Empire kills its enemies" — that fails the test instantly). The most dangerous failure mode is anything that lets players or GM settle into "so they're evil after all."

10 · What's Decided, What's Still Open

LOCKED (DON'T RE-LITIGATE)

- Players = a mixed commission of inquiry / circuit court (the Assize). Job, not identity.
- The hegemon is just "the Empire."
- The secret is a fusion (sacrifice + holding back a threat whose current reality is unknowable from inside).
- "Reconciliation" is kept out of the players' job title; the court's plain provisional name is "the Assize."
- Kessadi grievance stays *mundane-political* (stolen sovereignty, the lost water-judges, the siege dead) — *not* about the secret. The secret is reached via the frontier's silence.
- The Tallun are a distinct fourth people; the Sworn are a three-wing coalition with a figurehead (Nemara) but no true head; violence at campaign start is mostly civil + sabotage with the insurgent wing straining.
- Presiding Justice defaults to an NPC; the Assize's own muscle is a small personal detail, anything larger requisitioned from the Governor; the posting is *both* prestigious and a hardship.

THE TWO CANDIDATE NEXT MOVES (YOUR PICK)

1. **Task 2 — the secret's selection mechanism.** THE centerpiece: *who* pays the cost and *how they are chosen* — the single decision that determines whether the Empire stays defensible. Keep victims few, benefit vast, threat uncertain, selection not-obviously-unjust. (Sensitive enough you may want to design it with a person in the room, not fan it out.)
2. **Naming pass.** Lock all the provisional labels (Aurenne, Halden, Kessad, Outmark, Vaur, the Assize, Vaurin / Haldar / Kessadi / Tallun, Vaurehm, Ish-Karan, the Reave, the Sarne...) now that the cultures behind them exist.

Then, later: the revelation architecture (clue/reveal timeline by session milestone); magic & the Daggerheart fit in an orderly world; and the case-of-the-arc session structure.

Everything above is drafted and committed to the vault. The canonical write-ups (with GM notes and links) remain the source of truth: *The Premise*, *Themes*, and *The Cost* in 00 - Core / 11 - Secrets; the world and provinces in 01 / 04; peoples in 03; the Assize and the Sworn in 05; the three figures in 08.